Foods dogs can eat — and the 47 that need a second look

Most "can my dog eat this" charts give two answers — safe or toxic. That is not the question anyone actually has at nine in the evening with a dog watching them eat. The question is *how much*, and *which part*. Here are all 47 foods in four risk tiers, each row carrying the number that decides it.

The seven with no safe dose — the toxic end of the list

Seven of the 47 foods have no established safe amount at all. They are not "more dangerous" in the abstract — they are dangerous in quantities that arrive by accident, which is a different problem from a food you simply should not over-feed.

Food	The dose that matters
Chocolate	A 10 kg dog shows mild signs from 3–4 oz of milk chocolate, and from under half an ounce of baking chocolate — run the dose for your own dog's weight
Grapes and raisins	No threshold has ever been established — three grapes in a 5 kg dog is treated as seriously as a bunch in a 30 kg dog
Xylitol	About 50 mg/kg triggers the insulin crash; around 500 mg/kg risks liver injury
Macadamia nuts	Signs from about 1 g of nut per kg — a couple of nuts for a 10 kg dog
Caffeine	Mild signs from about 20 mg/kg, serious toxicity near 40–60 mg/kg, roughly 140 mg/kg fatal
Alcohol	Lethal at about 5.5–7.9 g of pure ethanol per kg — and it hides in rising dough and fallen fruit
Raw bread dough	Live yeast produces ethanol in a warm stomach while the dough expands inside the dog

Every one of those ends in a phone call rather than a portion. If you are reading this because one of them just happened, the numbers above are what the vet will ask for — read them out, then follow the instructions on that food's own page. For the emergency sequence itself — the symptoms that mean poisoning, the first ten minutes, and what not to do — the full toxic-foods list walks through it step by step.

Foods dogs can eat: the everyday list

The larger group, and the one that gets far less attention than it deserves. Fourteen of the 47 foods are ordinary, useful treats when they are plain and inside the 10% treat budget: plain cooked chicken, cooked eggs, white rice, carrots, cucumber, green beans, peas, blueberries, strawberries, watermelon (flesh only), plain pumpkin, cooked sweet potato, cooked salmon and peeled shrimp.

Two caveats survive even here. "Plain" is doing real work in that list — no salt, no butter, no onion or garlic powder, no xylitol — and the 10% ceiling applies to all of it. A dog can get fat on chicken and rice. The calorie figure for each of those 14 is in the tier table below, because the arithmetic is the part owners underestimate.

Why this chart is built differently

Three things separate this page from the wall charts and laminated posters. First, **every row carries a number**, not an adjective. "High in salt" tells you nothing; "1,000 mg of sodium per 100 g against a daily need of 200 mg" tells you whether tonight matters. Second, **there are four tiers instead of two**, because the largest group of foods — the ones that are perfectly fine except for one attached part — gets flattened into "toxic" by a two-tier chart, and people then panic over a

piece of watermelon and shrug at a macadamia nut. Third, **every row links to the page that shows its working**: the dose arithmetic, the source, and the date it was last checked.

If you only read one paragraph, read the tier definitions and then jump to the food you are holding.

The four tiers

Tier	Name	What it means
Tier 1	Everyday	Plain, cooked where relevant, and small enough to stay inside the treat budget. Nothing here needs a calculation beyond portion size.
Tier 2	A ceiling	Safe, but carries sugar, fat, lactose or a compound that stops being harmless at volume. These are the foods where the amount is the whole answer.
Tier 3	One part is the problem	The flesh is fine and something attached to it is not — a pit, a cob, a skin, a green stage, a mould. This is the tier people misread most often.
Tier 4	No safe dose	Either no amount has been established as safe, or the amount that causes harm is small enough to arrive by accident. These end in a phone call, not a portion.

The 10% rule, in numbers

Every "safe" verdict on this page sits on top of one rule: **treats of any kind should stay under about 10% of your dog's daily calories.** It is worth doing the arithmetic once, because the answer surprises most owners.

A 10 kg dog on a typical maintenance diet eats roughly 600 kcal a day. Ten per cent of that is **60 kcal** — and 60 kcal is:

- about two and a half medium carrots, or
- about three-quarters of a cup of blueberries, or
- one large egg and a small piece of chicken, or
- half a medium avocado, which would use the entire budget on 15% fat and no complete nutrition.

That is the whole reason a food can be "safe" and still be a bad idea. A dog does not need treats to be nutritious — it needs them to be small. When someone tells you their dog "only gets healthy treats" and the dog is overweight, this arithmetic is usually why.

Tier 1 — Safe as an everyday treat

These are the foods a vet will not sigh about. All of them still live inside the 10% rule below — a treat budget is a budget, not an exemption.

Food	What is safe	The number that matters
Can dogs eat chicken?	Plain, cooked, boneless, skinless	The default bland-diet protein; keep toppers under 10% of daily calories
Can dogs eat eggs?	Fully cooked, no shell	About 70 kcal and 6 g protein per large egg
Can dogs eat rice?	Plain white, cooked, no salt or butter	About 205 kcal per cooked cup
Can dogs eat carrots?	Raw, cooked or frozen	About 25 kcal per medium carrot — roughly half a biscuit
Can dogs eat cucumber?	Sliced, peeled or not	About 8 kcal per half cup; 96% water
Can dogs eat green beans?	Plain, cooked or raw, no salt	About 31 kcal per cooked cup

Food	What is safe	The number that matters
Can dogs eat peas?	Plain, fresh or frozen, no salt	About 81 kcal and 5 g protein per 100 g
Can dogs eat blueberries?	Fresh or frozen, unsweetened	About 84 kcal per cup, almost no fat
Can dogs eat strawberries?	Fresh, hulled, no sugar	About 32 kcal per 100 g
Can dogs eat watermelon?	Flesh only — no rind, no seeds	About 45 kcal per diced cup; 92% water
Can dogs eat pumpkin?	Plain canned or cooked — never pie filling	About 0.17 g of fibre per tablespoon, so the famous 'spoon of pumpkin' is a small dose
Can dogs eat sweet potato?	Cooked and plain; raw is hard to digest	Baked spikes blood sugar far more than boiled — relevant for diabetic dogs
Can dogs eat salmon?	Cooked, boneless, plain	A genuine omega-3 source; never raw, and never the smoked kind
Can dogs eat shrimp?	Cooked, peeled, unseasoned	About 110 mg sodium per 100 g — and two to four times that if STPP-treated

Tier 2 — Safe, with a ceiling

Every food in this tier is fine in a small amount and unhelpful in a large one. The ceilings below are the actual reason these foods show up in vet visits: not toxicity, arithmetic.

Food	What is safe	The number that matters
Can dogs eat apples?	Flesh only — no core, no seeds	About 50 kcal per 100 g; 2–3 thin slices for a dog under 5 kg
Can dogs eat bananas?	Peeled flesh	One 1 cm slice per 5 kg of body weight
Can dogs eat mango?	Flesh only, no skin, no pit	About 50 kcal and 11 g sugar per 83 g
Can dogs eat pineapple?	Fresh, or canned in juice and drained	About 42 kcal per 80 g fresh; canned carries 12–14 g sugar per 100 g
Can dogs eat peaches?	Flesh only, fresh, no skin if it upsets the gut	About 12 g sugar per 100 g, most of it in the juice
Can dogs eat yogurt?	Plain, unsweetened, live cultures	4.5–5 g lactose per 100 g; Greek is lower at 3–4 g
Can dogs eat milk?	Generally not — most adults cannot digest it	Lactase falls after weaning, so a bowl usually means gas and loose stool
Can dogs eat cheese?	Plain hard cheese, small cube	About 180 mg sodium per 30 g of cheddar
Can dogs eat bread?	Plain baked bread, thumbnail-sized piece	About 70 kcal per 25 g slice, with almost no usable nutrition
Can dogs eat honey?	Plain honey, a dab	About 17 g of sugar per tablespoon
Can dogs eat popcorn?	Air-popped, no butter, no salt	About 8 g and 31 kcal per cup; unpopped kernels are the dental risk
Can dogs eat peanut butter?	Plain — and check the label for xylitol every time	Two teaspoons a day is plenty for a medium dog
Can dogs eat broccoli?	Plain, steamed or raw, chopped	Keep to about 10% of daily calories; isothiocyanates irritate the gut above that

Food	What is safe	The number that matters
Can dogs eat spinach?	Cooked, small amount, water poured off	750 mg oxalate per 100 g raw; blanching removes 30–50%

Tier 3 — The flesh is fine, one part is not

This is the tier that causes the most unnecessary panic and the most unnecessary vet bills, in roughly equal measure. In every case the answer depends on which part the dog got, not on the food itself.

Food	What is safe	The number that matters
Can dogs eat almonds?	Sweet almonds, a few, never whole for a small dog	Sweet and bitter almonds differ about fifty-fold in cyanide; 5–20 bitter almonds can kill a 10 kg dog
Can dogs eat avocado?	Flesh only — no pit, no skin	About 15% fat; half a medium avocado is roughly 160 kcal
Can dogs eat cherries?	Flesh only, pitted	The pit is a physical obstruction first and a cyanide source second; wilted leaves are worse than the fruit
Can dogs eat corn?	Kernels cut off the cob	A cob is 15–20 cm long and 4–5 cm across — wider than the small intestine of most dogs
Can dogs eat garlic?	None — this is the toxic end of the tier	About 5 g per kg of body weight; three to five times more potent than onion per gram
Can dogs eat onion?	None — raw, cooked or powdered	About 15–30 g per kg of body weight; onion powder is concentrated
Can dogs eat potato?	Cooked, peeled, plain	Raw, green or sprouted potatoes carry solanine; cooking does not remove it from a green potato
Can dogs eat tomato?	Ripe red flesh only — no stem, no leaves, no green fruit	Green tomato runs 90–320 mg/kg solanine; ripe red is under 5 mg/kg
Can dogs eat walnuts?	Fresh English walnuts, one or two	Black or mouldy walnuts carry tremorgenic mycotoxins — a same-day vet visit, not a wait-and-see
Can dogs eat ham?	A few plain shreds, rarely	1,000–1,200 mg sodium per 100 g against a 10 kg dog's ~200 mg daily need
Can dogs eat ice cream?	A lick of plain vanilla, if dairy sits well	About 4 g lactose per 65 g scoop; every 'sugar-free' tub needs a xylitol check
Can dogs eat plums?	Flesh only, pitted	About 1.3 g sorbitol per dried plum — enough to loosen the gut in a small dog

Tier 4 — No established safe dose

Do not wait for symptoms in this tier. The relevant instruction is a phone call, and the numbers below are what you read out to the vet.

Food	What is safe	The number that matters
Can dogs eat alcohol?	None	Lethal at about 5.5–7.9 g of pure ethanol per kg, and it hides in rising dough and fallen fruit
Can dogs eat caffeine?	None	Mild signs from about 20 mg/kg, serious toxicity near 40–60 mg/kg, roughly 140 mg/kg fatal
Can dogs eat chocolate?	None	A 10 kg dog shows mild signs from 3–4 oz of milk chocolate but under half an ounce of baking chocolate

Food	What is safe	The number that matters
Can dogs eat grapes?	None — grapes and raisins alike	No safe amount has ever been established; a 5 kg dog and three grapes is the same danger zone as a 30 kg dog and a bunch
Can dogs eat macadamia nuts?	None	Signs from about 1 g of nut per kg — a couple of nuts for a 10 kg dog
Can dogs eat xylitol?	None	About 50 mg/kg triggers the insulin crash; around 500 mg/kg risks liver injury
Can dogs eat raw dough?	None	Live yeast produces ethanol in a warm stomach, and the dough expands while it does

The three mistakes that cause most of the trouble

"A little bit can't hurt." In Tier 4, a little bit is the dose. Macadamia nuts produce tremors from about 1 g of nut per kilogram of body weight — for a 10 kg dog that is a couple of nuts, not a handful. Xylitol reaches the blood-sugar threshold at 50 mg/kg, which is less than a single piece of some sugar-free gums for a small dog. The phrase "a little bit" is calibrated for humans eating human food, and it does not transfer.

"It's natural, so it's gentle." Xylitol is a plant-derived sweetener sold in health-food aisles. Amygdalin is marketed online as "vitamin B17". Black walnuts are simply walnuts that fell off a tree. Natural describes where a compound came from, not what it does to a dog's liver. The most dangerous items on this chart are all natural.

"He's eaten it before and was fine." This one is true for grapes and false as a safety argument. Individual dogs vary enormously in how they handle grape ingestion — some have survived a handful with no effect, others have gone into kidney failure after a few. No safe amount has ever been established, which means a previous uneventful grape is evidence about one dog on one day, not a green light.

What this chart deliberately leaves out

Being clear about the edges is part of being trustworthy about the middle. This chart does not cover:

- **Raw and undercooked meat.** The risk is bacterial (Salmonella, Listeria, E. coli) rather than toxic, it depends on the supply chain, and it is a separate argument from "is this food poisonous".
- **Medication, supplements and human vitamins.** These follow completely different dose logic and deserve their own page, not a row here.
- **Your dog's own history.** A dog with pancreatitis should not be eating anything in the high-fat column regardless of tier. A dog with a calcium oxalate stone history should skip spinach outright. The chart gives the general answer; your vet gives yours.
- **Breed-specific sensitivity.** Some breeds — Akitas and Shibas among them — are markedly more sensitive to Allium damage than the average dog, which moves garlic and onion from "avoid" to "strictly avoid" for them.

If something on this chart already happened

Skip the rest of the page and call. Have three things ready, because the vet will ask for all of them: **what the food was** (including the brand and whether it was sugar-free), **how much** (the packet is better than an estimate), and **your dog's weight**. Those three answers decide the treatment, and "he ate some gum" cannot be converted into a dose by anyone.

Do not induce vomiting unless a vet tells you to. For caustic or sharp items it makes the damage worse, and for some toxins the timing has already passed.

Sources and how this chart is maintained

The dose figures here are drawn from veterinary toxicology references and the underlying case literature, and each linked page names its own sources. Where a number is contested — the threshold for garlic, the exact toxic principle in avocado — the linked page says so rather than picking the tidiest figure.

Every row is re-checked on a rolling six-month cycle, and immediately when a source changes. If a number here disagrees with a source you trust, write to contact@wagwise.org with the row and the source, and it gets fixed and re-dated. The editorial standards page explains how the guides are written and reviewed.

Using this chart. You are welcome to cite it, quote a row, or reproduce the tier structure with attribution and a link back to this page. It is kept current precisely so that other people can rely on it rather than re-deriving the numbers.

Last full review: 2 November 2026. This page is general information, not veterinary advice. For anything urgent, call your vet or the nearest emergency clinic.

Vet clinics, breeders, shelter pages and pet blogs are welcome to reuse it. The CSV is the source data for the table, and the iframe is the whole widget — it sets no cookie and needs no script from us. The table scrolls inside the frame, so it stays readable on a phone instead of running for three thousand pixels.

For a wall rather than a screen, the buttons at the top of this page download two PDFs: a one-page poster with the seven foods that have no safe dose, and the six-page chart for a folder. Both print on A4 and carry the source address in the footer.